

Psalms 83

That They May Know Thy Name

That men may know that thou... art the most high over all the earth

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Keep not thou silence, O God: hold not thy peace, and be not still, O God.*
- 2 *For, lo, thine enemies make a tumult: and they that hate thee have lifted up the head.*
- 3 *They have taken crafty counsel against thy people, and consulted against thy hidden ones.*
- 4 *They have said, Come, and let us cut them off from being a nation; that the name of Israel may be no more in remembrance.*
- 5 *For they have consulted together with one consent: they are confederate against thee:*
- 6 *The tabernacles of Edom, and the Ishmaelites; of Moab, and the Hagarenes;*
- 7 *Gebal, and Ammon, and Amalek; the Philistines with the inhabitants of Tyre;*
- 8 *Assur also is joined with them: they have holpen the children of Lot. Selah.*
- 9 *Do unto them as unto the Midianites; as to Sisera, as to Jabin, at the brook of Kison:*
- 10 *Which perished at Endor: they became as dung for the earth.*
- 11 *Make their nobles like Oreb, and like Zeeb: yea, all their princes as Zebah, and as Zalmunna:*
- 12 *Who said, Let us take to ourselves the houses of God in possession.*
- 13 *O my God, make them like a wheel; as the stubble before the wind.*
- 14 *As the fire burneth a wood, and as the flame setteth the mountains on fire;*
- 15 *So persecute them with thy tempest, and make them afraid with thy storm.*
- 16 *Fill their faces with shame; that they may seek thy name, O LORD.*
- 17 *Let them be confounded and troubled for ever; yea, let them be put to shame, and perish:*
- 18 *That men may know that thou, whose name alone is JEHOVAH, art the most high over all the earth.*

2 · CONTEXT

Asaph names a coalition of surrounding nations—Edom, Ishmaelites, Moab, the Ammonites, Amalek, Philistia, Tyre, and Assyria—united against Israel, and calls on God to act as decisively as He did against earlier enemies like Sisera and Midian. The petition's ultimate concern, stated explicitly in the final verse, is not merely Israel's safety but that these very nations would come to know God's name and supremacy. Henry treats this as intercession that keeps God's glory, not just national survival, as its true aim.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

The urgent plea opens: do not stay silent or still, for your enemies are in an uproar, and those who hate you have raised their heads. Their scheme is stated with chilling clarity—wipe Israel out entirely so that its name is remembered no more among the nations.

Verse 5-8

A roll call of the confederated enemies follows—Edom and the Ishmaelites, Moab and the Hagarenes, Gebal, Ammon, and Amalek, Philistia and the people of Tyre, with Assyria also joining as reinforcement. The comprehensiveness of the list underscores the scale of the threat—this is coordinated hostility from every direction.

Verse 9-12

The psalmist prays for a repeat of God's historic victories: as He did to Midian, to Sisera and Jabin at the river Kishon who perished and became like dung on the ground, so let Him do to these leaders who said, 'let us take the pastures of God for our own possession.' Past deliverances become the pattern requested for the present crisis.

Verse 13-15

Vivid images of total, decisive judgment follow: let the enemy be like whirling dust, like stubble before the wind; let them be pursued and terrified like a forest ablaze or a mountain set on fire by tempest and storm.

Verse 16-18

The psalm's true aim surfaces in its final lines: let their faces be filled with shame so they seek God's name; let them be confounded and perish in a way that finally makes clear that God alone, whose name is the LORD, is the Most High over all the earth. National deliverance is requested explicitly as a means to a greater end—that even hostile nations would come to know who God actually is.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Intercession for deliverance from real, coordinated threats can and should be shaped by a concern larger than mere survival—that even those currently hostile to God would ultimately come to know and acknowledge Him. The psalm models urgent, specific prayer against real danger held together with a missional hope that judgment itself might lead enemies toward recognition of God's supremacy.

Application for life today.

When facing coordinated opposition or a threat that feels overwhelming in scale, pray as specifically and urgently as this psalm does rather than settling for vague requests. Let verse 18 reshape your ultimate hope in conflict: pray not only for your own deliverance but that even those opposing you might come to know God truly. Notice how remembering God's past victories (vv. 9–12) can fuel present-day confidence in prayer.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What coordinated or overwhelming opposition in your life would benefit from the specific, named urgency this psalm models (vv. 1–8)?

2. How does praying for your opponents' ultimate recognition of God (v. 18), rather than only their defeat, change the tone of your intercession?

3. Which past deliverance—personal or biblical—could you draw on as this psalm does (vv. 9–12) to fuel confidence in a current struggle?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).